

Notes: Ellison (JPE, 2002)
The Slowdown of the Economics Publishing Process

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1 Big picture

- **Question.** Why did economics journal publication lags become much longer between the 1970s and the late 1990s?
- **Main fact.** Submit-to-accept times at several top journals grew from roughly six to twelve months in the early 1970s to roughly two years or more by the late 1990s.
- **Main decomposition.** Slower first responses explain only part of the slowdown; more rounds of revision and longer author revision cycles are central.
- **Main interpretation.** Observable changes explain only part of the slowdown. A large residual is consistent with changing social norms about what referees and editors require before acceptance.
- **Economic importance.** Review delays affect the allocation of research time, the timing of careers, and the speed of idea diffusion.

2 Incremental contribution

- **Comprehensive measurement.** The paper assembles a long-run data set on submit-accept times, first-response times, revisions, field composition, citations, author characteristics, and journal output.
- **Process decomposition.** It separates referee response delays from revision/resubmission delays.
- **Diagnostic design.** It tests many candidate explanations rather than offering a single story.
- **Institutional economics contribution.** It treats journal review as a production technology for research and therefore as an economic institution.
- **Connection to theory.** It motivates the companion q-r model of evolving academic standards.

3 Data and measurement

The central outcome is submit-to-accept time, usually including author revision time. First-response time measures the initial editorial/referee response. Paper-level data cover top-journal articles by decade. Field classifications are based on JEL codes. Journal prestige is measured using normalized citation ratios. Author specialization and editor expertise are constructed with field concentration and field-distance measures.

Interpretation: The paper combines many imperfect data sources to triangulate the causes of an institutional slowdown.

4 Models and empirical specifications

4.1 Paper-level lag regression

$$Lag_{ijt} = \alpha_j + \tau_j t + FieldFE_f + \beta' X_{ijt} + \epsilon_{ijt}.$$

Interpretation: *Lag* is the time from submission to acceptance. Journal effects, journal trends, and field effects absorb persistent journal and field differences.

4.2 Author specialization

$$\gamma_i = \frac{\sum_f (s_{if} - x_f)^2 - \frac{1}{N_i} (1 - \sum_f x_f^2)}{(1 - 1/N_i)(1 - \sum_f x_f^2)}.$$

Interpretation: A rise would indicate that economists became more specialized. The evidence does not show a strong profession-wide increase.

4.3 Field distance and editor expertise

$$c(f, g) = \frac{P(f, g) - P(f)P(g)}{\sqrt{P(f)(1 - P(f))P(g)(1 - P(g))}}, \quad d(f, g) = 1 - \frac{c(f, g)}{\sqrt{c(f, f)c(g, g)}}.$$

Interpretation: EditorDistance tests whether papers further from the editor’s expertise take longer. The evidence is mixed.

4.4 Prestige-change regression

$$\Delta MeanLag_{it} = \alpha + \beta \frac{\Delta NCiteRatio_{it}}{NCiteRatio_{i,t-\Delta t}} + \text{decade dummies} + u_{it}.$$

Interpretation: Increased competition for high-prestige journal space explains some, but not all, of the slowdown.

5 Identification and empirical design

The paper is diagnostic rather than a single causal experiment. The identification logic is triangulation: a proposed mechanism must match time-series trends, cross-sectional paper-level regressions, journal-level changes, and field-level patterns. The strongest decomposition result is that longer review cycles are not only first-response delays; more extensive revisions matter. Limits include heterogeneous data definitions, selected published-paper samples, and indirect measurement of social norms.

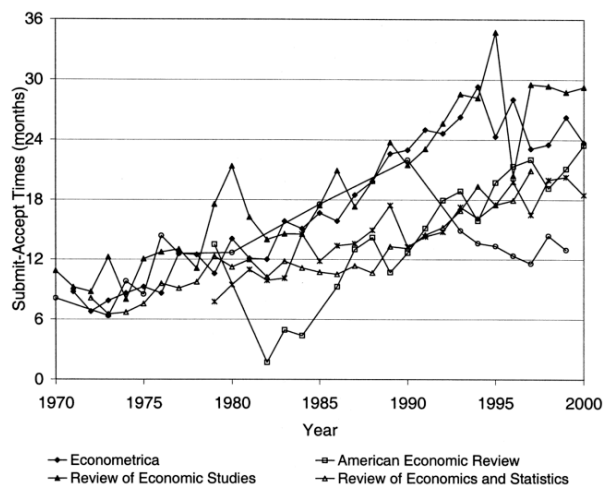
6 Tables and figures

6.1 Figure 1: Mean Submit-Accept Times + Table 1: Mean Submit-Accept Times at Various Journals

Read: Figure 1 documents rising submit-accept times across top journals. Table 1 shows the pattern across many journals.

Detailed interpretation: The slowdown is broad, but the QJE after the early 1990s shows that editorial policy can shorten lags.

Economic message: Publication delays are a widespread institutional change, not a one-journal anomaly.



(a) Figure 1: Mean submit-accept times

TABLE 1
MEAN SUBMIT-ACCEPT TIMES AT VARIOUS JOURNALS

JOURNAL	MEAN TOTAL REVIEW TIME IN YEAR			
	1970	1980	1990	1999
Top Five General-Interest Journals				
<i>AER</i>		13.5 [*]	12.7	21.1
<i>Econometrica</i>	8.8 [†]	14.0 [†]	22.9 [†]	26.3 [†]
<i>JPE</i>		9.5	13.3	20.3
<i>QJE</i>	8.1	12.7	22.0	13.0
<i>REStud</i>	10.9 [†]	21.5	21.2	28.8
Other General-Interest Journals				
<i>Canadian J. Econ.</i>		11.3 [*]		16.6
<i>Econ. Inquiry</i>		3.4 [*]		13.0
<i>Econ. J.</i>		9.5 [*]		18.2 [†]
<i>Internat. Econ. Rev.</i>	7.8 [†]	11.9 [†]	15.9 [†]	16.8 [†]
<i>REStat</i>	8.1	11.4	13.1	18.8
Economics Field Journals				
<i>J. Appl. Econometrics</i>			16.3 [†]	21.5 [†]
<i>J. Comparative Econ.</i>		10.3 [†]	10.9 [†]	10.1 [†]
<i>J. Development Econ.</i>	5.6 ^{†‡}	6.4 [†]	12.6 [†]	17.3 [†]
<i>J. Econometrics</i>		9.7 [†]	17.6 [†]	25.5 [†]
<i>J. Econ. Theory</i>	.6 [†]	6.1 [†]	17.0 [†]	16.4 [†]
<i>J. Environmental Econ. and Management</i>		5.5 [†]	6.6 [†]	13.1 [†]
<i>J. Internat. Econ.</i>		8.7 [*]		16.2
<i>J. Law and Econ.</i>		6.6 [*]		14.8
<i>J. Math. Econ.</i>	2.2 ^{†‡}	7.5 [†]	17.5	8.5
<i>J. Monetary Econ.</i>			11.7 [†]	16.0 [†]
<i>J. Public Econ.</i>	2.6 ^{†§}	12.5 [†]	14.2 [†]	9.9 [†]
<i>J. Urban Econ.</i>		5.4 [†]	10.3 [†]	8.8 [†]
<i>Rand J. Econ.</i>		7.2 [*]	20.0	20.9
Journals in Related Fields				
<i>Accounting Rev.</i>		10.1	20.7	14.5
<i>J. Accounting and Econ.</i>		11.4 [†]	12.5 [†]	11.5 [†]
<i>J. Finance</i>		6.5 [*]		18.6
<i>J. Financial Econ.</i>	2.6 ^{†‡}	7.5 [†]	12.4 [†]	14.8 [†]

^{*} Date from Yohe (1980) pertain to 1979 and probably do not include the review time for the final resubmission.
[†] Does not include review time for final resubmission.
[‡] Data for 1974.
[§] Data for 1972.

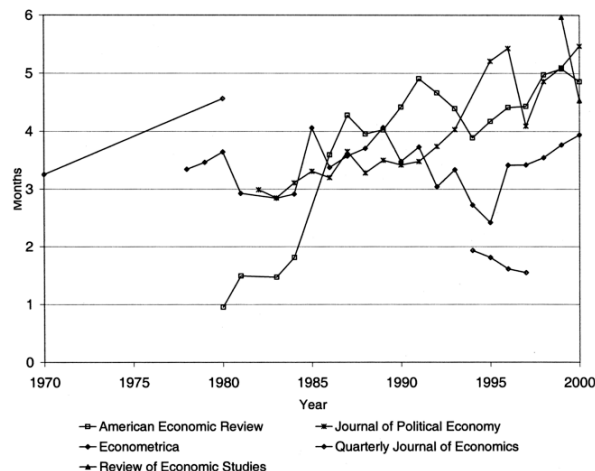
(b) Table 1: Mean submit-accept times

6.2 Figure 2: Mean First-Response Times + Tables 2–3

Read: Figure 2 shows first-response times; Table 2 compares accepted and other papers; Table 3 documents QJE revisions.

Detailed interpretation: First responses rise, but revisions are the main source of the total lag increase. The QJE historical data show revision counts and author revision time rising.

Economic message: The slowdown is largely a revision-intensity phenomenon.



(a) Figure 2: Mean first-response times

TABLE 2
FIRST-RESPONSE TIMES FOR ACCEPTED AND OTHER PAPERS

SAMPLE OF PAPERS	MEAN FIRST-RESPONSE TIME IN MONTHS									
	1970	1980	1985	1990	1992	1993	1994	1995	1996	1997
<i>QJE</i> :										
Sent to referees	3.3	4.6					3.5	3.2	2.9	2.7
Accepted	4.8	5.8	7.2	9.0			4.8	3.7	3.2	3.7
<i>JPE</i> :										
Rejected			3.3	3.4	3.7	4.0		5.2	5.4	4.1
Accepted					6.9	6.7	6.9	8.4	10.3	7.8

NOTE.—The first row gives estimated mean first-response times for papers with responses in 1970 and 1980 and the actual means for all papers with first responses in 1994–97 from the *QJE*. (The later means are computed omitting data on papers rejected without using referees.) The second row gives mean first-response times for papers that were eventually accepted. For 1970–90, the means pertain to papers published in the indicated year. For 1994–97, numbers are means for papers with first responses in the indicated year and accepted before August 1999. The third row gives mean first-response times for papers that were rejected on the initial submission by the *JPE* in the indicated year. The fourth row gives means for papers with first responses in the indicated year that were accepted before January 1999.

(b) Table 2: First-response times

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TABLE 3
REVISIONS AT THE *QJE*

	YEAR OF PUBLICATION									
	1940	1950	1960	1970	1980	1985	1990	1995	1997	
Mean submit-accept time (months)	3.7	3.8	3.6	8.1	12.7	17.6	22.0	13.4	11.6	
Mean number of revisions	.6	.8	.6	1.2	1.4	1.5	1.7	2.2	2.0	
Mean number of revisions before acceptance	.4	.1	.2	.5	.8	1.0	1.7	2.2	2.0	
Mean author time for first preaccept revision (months)	1.4	2.1	2.0	2.1	3.0	4.2	3.6	4.1	4.7	

Table 3: Revisions at the QJE

6.3 Tables 4–6: Author Characteristics, Paper Characteristics, and Lag Regressions

Read: Tables 4–6 test democratization, composition, and complexity stories.

Detailed interpretation: Papers become longer and more coauthored, but outsider composition does not explain the slowdown.

Economic message: Observable paper and author changes explain only a limited part of the delay growth.

	DECADE				
	1950s	1960s	1970s	1980s	1990s
Author-level					
Herfindahl			.00138	.00142	.00135
Percentage					
from top					
eight schools	36.5	31.8	27.2	28.2	33.8
Harvard share					
of <i>QJE</i>	14.5	12.3	12.7	6.4	12.5
Chicago share					
of <i>JPE</i>	15.6	10.6	11.2	7.0	9.4
Non-English					

(a) Table 4: Author characteristics

VARIABLE	SAMPLE					
	1970s		1980s		1990s	
	(N=1,564)		(N=1,154)		(N=1,413)	
	Mean	Standard Deviation	Mean	Standard Deviation	Mean	Standard Deviation
Lag	300.14	220.27	498.03	273.84	659.55	360.90
AuBrookP	.07	.45	.06	.30	.09	.35
AuP&P	.19	.49	.27	.70	.35	.78
AuTop5PubsLast5	.80	1.37	.93	1.09	.79	.99
AuTop5Pubs70s	2.20	2.51	1.02	1.77	.42	1.34
SchoolTop5Pubs	...	...	...	...	35.47	32.07
EnglishName	.65	.45	.67	.43	.66	.41
Female	.03	.16	.04	.17	.07	.22
UnknownName	.09	.29	.02	.15	.01	.11
NumAuthor	1.39	.60	1.49	.64	1.73	.71
Pages	13.09	6.37	17.43	7.52	24.20	8.72
JournalHQ	...	...	...	...	.08	.27
NBER	...	...	...	...	.17	.37
Order	6.81	4.08	6.40	3.70	5.39	3.15
log(1+Cites)	2.52	1.31	2.90	1.27	2.33	1.03
EditorDistance	...	...	...	...	.81	.25

(b) Table 5: Paper-level summary statistics

VARIABLE	SAMPLE		
	1970s (N=1,564) (1)	1980s (N=1,154) (2)	1990s (N=1,413) (3)
AuBrookP	10.1 (.77)	-28.7 (.93)	-24.4 (1.15)
AuP&P	-8.3 (.66)	14.4 (.99)	15.5 (1.22)
AuTop5PubsLast5	-8.6 (1.92)	2.4 (.27)	-9.5 (1.00)
AuTop5Pubs70s	...	.2 (.04)	4.4 (.64)
SchoolTop5Pubs	...	...	-5 (1.37)
EnglishName	1.2 (.09)	3.1 (.16)	-2.2 (.10)
Female	-35.8 (1.05)	-54.8 (1.20)	56.8 (1.28)
UnknownName	4.7 (.22)	-8.7 (.16)	-4 (.01)
NumAuthor	-19.1 (2.10)	17.6 (1.39)	31.0 (2.31)
Pages	5.6 (5.57)	5.0 (3.90)	5.3 (4.28)
JournalHQ	...	...	11.6 (.33)
NBERQJE	...	...	-22.5 (.59)
Order	1.8 (1.25)	4.9 (2.08)	8.8 (2.76)
log(1+Cites)	-21.7 (4.91)	-12.2 (1.70)	-40.7 (3.86)
Journal dummies	yes	yes	yes
Journal trends	yes	yes	yes
Field dummies	yes	yes	yes
R ²	.11	.10	.19

NOTE.—Absolute values of *t*-statistics are in parentheses. The dependent variable, Lag, is the length of time between submission of a paper to a journal and its acceptance in days. The sample is subsets of the set of papers published in the top five or six general-interest economics journals between 1970 and 1998 as described in the text. All regressions include journal dummies, journal-specific linear time trends, and dummies for 17 fields of economics.

Table 6: Basic submit-accept time regressions

6.4 Tables 7–10: Fields, Specialization, and Editor Expertise

Read: Tables 7–10 evaluate whether complexity and specialization explain longer lags.

Detailed interpretation: Author specialization indices show little clear increase, and EditorDistance has mixed predictive power.

Economic message: Specialization is not the main explanation for the slowdown.

TABLE 7
FIELD BREAKDOWN OF ARTICLES IN THE TOP FIVE JOURNALS

FIELD	PERCENTAGE OF PAPERS		
	1970s	1980s	1990s
Microeconomic theory	25.8	29.5	22.7
Macroeconomics	16.8	15.5	21.2
Econometrics	10.5	9.1	8.7
Labor	9.8	9.0	8.6
Industrial organization	7.3	11.0	8.3
International	6.9	5.4	5.6
Public finance	6.1	5.3	5.3
Finance	3.2	5.3	7.7
Development	3.8	1.4	1.6
Experimental	.4	1.3	2.5
Urban	2.2	.7	1.1
History	1.1	1.9	1.0
Political economy	1.1	.6	1.9
Productivity	1.4	1.2	.9
Environmental	.4	.4	.8
Law and economics	.8	.8	1.0

(a) Table 7: Field breakdown

TABLE 8
SPECIALIZATION OF AUTHORS AT LEVEL OF MAJOR FIELD

CLASSIFICATION OF 1990s PAPERS	MEAN SPECIALIZATION INDEX		
	1970s	1980s	1990s
Best possible	.33	.33	.37
Consistent use of old JEL codes	.33	.33	.31

NOTE.—The table reports Ellison-Glaeser concentration indexes reflecting authors' tendencies to concentrate their writings in a few major fields.

from the 1970s to the 1980s followed by an increase from the 1980s to the 1990s. International economics has the opposite pattern.³⁵

(b) Table 8: Major-field specialization

TABLE 9
SPECIALIZATION OF AUTHORS WITHIN SUBFIELDS OF EACH MAJOR
FIELD

FIELD	INDEX OF WITHIN-FIELD SPECIALIZATION		
	1970s	1980s	1990s
Microeconomic theory	.38	.32	.31
Macroeconomics	.27	.17	.23
Industrial organization	.35	.30	.19
Labor	.28	.22	.11
International	.25	.35	.27
Public finance	.50	.28	.18
Finance	.29	.20	.42

NOTE.—The table reports Ellison-Glaeser concentration indexes reflecting authors' tendencies to concentrate their writings in a few subfields.

(a) Table 9: Within-field specialization

TABLE 10
EFFECT OF EDITOR EXPERTISE ON SUBMIT-ACCEPT TIMES

INDEPENDENT VARIABLE	DEPENDENT VARIABLE: SUBMIT-ACCEPT TIME		
	(1)	(2)	(3)
EditorDistance	-67.9 (1.4)	-143.9 (3.4)	-23.9 (.5)
Editor fixed effects	yes	yes	no
Field fixed effects	yes	no	yes
Journal fixed effects and trends	no	no	yes
Other variables from table 6	yes	yes	yes
R ²	.29	.28	.19

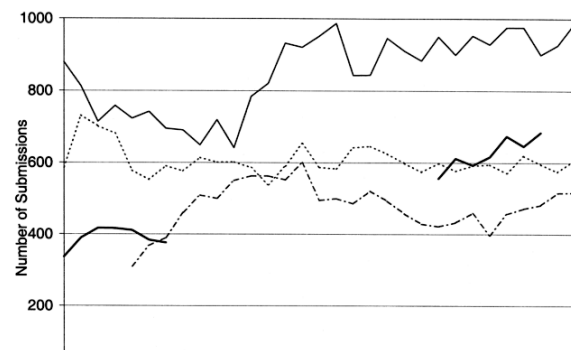
(b) Table 10: Editor expertise

6.5 Figure 3 and Tables 11–13: Growth and Competition

Read: Figure 3 shows rising submissions. Table 11 shows article slots do not grow proportionally. Table 12 tracks journal citation hierarchy. Table 13 links prestige changes to lag changes.

Detailed interpretation: Increased competition for top-journal space explains some months of the slowdown, especially outside the QJE outlier.

Economic message: Growth and competition matter, but they leave a large residual.



(a) Figure 3: Submissions to top journals

TABLE 11
NUMBER OF FULL-LENGTH ARTICLES PER YEAR IN TOP JOURNALS

JOURNAL	NUMBER OF ARTICLES PER YEAR		
	1970–79	1980–89	1990–97
<i>AER</i>	53	50	55
<i>Econometrica</i>	74	69	46
<i>JPE</i>	71	58	48
<i>QJE</i>	30	41	43
<i>REStud</i>	43	47	39

sions to *AER* dropped between 1970 and 1980, grew substantially be

(b) Table 11: Articles per year

TABLE 12
RECENT CITATION RATIOS: AVERAGE OF THE TOP FIVE JOURNALS NORMALIZED TO ONE

JOURNAL	VALUE OF NCiteRatio			
	1970	1980	1990	1998
Top Five General-Interest Journals				
<i>AER</i>	1.01*	1.02	.73	.64
<i>Econometrica</i>	.86	.95	1.71	1.00
<i>JPE</i>	.81	1.69	1.11	1.23
<i>QJE</i>	.94	.61	.74	1.37
<i>REStud</i>	1.38	.74	.71	.76
Next-Tier General-Interest Journals				
<i>Econ. J.</i>	.65	.78	.49	.33
<i>Internat. Econ. Rev.</i>	.53	.53	.26	.20
<i>REStat</i>	.95	.65	.36	.29
Average for group	.71	.65	.37	.28
Top Field Journals in Major Fields				
<i>J. Development Econ.</i>		.28 [†]	.30	.16
<i>J. Econometrics</i>		.49 ^{†‡}	.53	.36
<i>J. Econ. Theory</i>	.78 [§]	.69	.40	.21
<i>J. Internat. Econ.</i>		.35	.38	.26
<i>J. Law and Econ.</i>	.71	1.26	.87	.51
<i>J. Monetary Econ.</i>		.87 [†]	.81	.45
<i>J. Public Econ.</i>		.56 [†]	.34	.19
<i>J. Urban Econ.</i>		.61 [†]	.28	.24
<i>Public Econ</i>		.11	.20 [§]	.21

(a) Table 12: Citation ratios

TABLE 13
EFFECT OF JOURNAL PRESTIGE ON SUBMIT-ACCEPT TIMES
Dependent Variable: $\Delta \text{MeanLag}_i$

INDEPENDENT VARIABLE	SAMPLE	
	Full (N=45) (1)	No <i>QJE</i> 98 (N=44) (2)
$\Delta \text{NCiteRatio}_i \div \text{NCiteRatio}_{i-\Delta t}$	1.0 (.4)	5.6 (2.5)
Dum7080_i	5.7 (3.1)	6.6 (4.0)
Dum8090_i	5.5 (4.9)	6.4 (6.4)
Dum9098_i	2.4 (2.2)	4.4 (4.1)
R^2	.55	.65

(b) Table 13: Journal prestige and lags

6.6 Tables 14–15 and Table A1: Field Norms

Read: Tables 14–15 show field and theory-subfield differences in lags. Table A1 lists field-distance neighbors.

Detailed interpretation: Field heterogeneity is consistent with the idea that review standards are partly learned within research communities.

Economic message: Social norms and field cultures are plausible residual explanations.

TABLE 14
MEAN SUBMIT-ACCEPT TIMES BY FIELD IN THE 1990s

Field	Number of Papers	Mean Submit-Accept Time
Econometrics	148	25.7
Development	24	24.7
Industrial organization	108	23.2
Theory	356	22.9
Experimental	35	22.5
Finance	117	21.6
Labor	105	20.8
History	12	20.6
Macroeconomics	282	20.4
International	69	19.3
Political economy	30	18.6
Public finance	60	17.9
Productivity	15	16.9

(a) Table 14: Times by field

TABLE 15
MEAN SUBMIT-ACCEPT TIMES FOR THEORY SUBFIELDS IN THE 1990s

Field	Number of Papers	Mean Submit-Accept Time
General equilibrium	34	27.9
Game theory	82	26.3
Unclassified	32	22.3
Decision theory	28	22.1
Price theory	59	21.9
Learning	13	21.6
Contract theory	59	21.2
Auction theory	13	19.3
Social choice	10	19.0

(b) Table 15: Theory subfields

TABLE A1 CLOSEST FIELDS IN THE FIELD-TO-FIELD DISTANCE MEASURE			
Field	Three Closest Fields		
Micro theory: Unclassified	Industrial organization	Micro: welfare economics	Micro: general equilibrium
Price theory	Micro: unclassified	Micro: welfare economics	Micro: decision theory
General equilibrium	Micro: unclassified	Micro: welfare economics	Micro: game theory
Welfare economics	Micro: unclassified	Public finance	Micro: general equilibrium
Game theory	Micro: learning	Micro: contract theory	Micro: social choice
Social choice	Political economy	Experimental	Micro: welfare economics
Contract theory	Micro: learning	Micro: game theory	Micro: unclassified
Auctions	Experimental	Micro: contract theory	Industrial organization
Decision theory	Micro: price theory	Micro: unclassified	Micro: game theory
Learning	Micro: game theory	Micro: contract theory	Finance: unclassified
Macro: Unclassified	Finance: unclassified	International: interna- tional finance	Macro: growth
Growth	Productivity	Development	Macro: transition
Transition	Finance: corporate	Law and economics	Development
Econometrics: Unclassified	Econometrics: time series		
Time series	Econometrics: unclassified		
Industrial organization	Micro: unclassified	Micro: contract theory	Micro: auctions
Labor	Urban	Public finance	
International: Unclassified	International: interna- tional finance	Development	Macro: growth
International finance	International: unclassified	Macro: transition	Macro: unclassified
Public finance	Micro: welfare economics	Environmental	Urban
Finance: Unclassified	Micro: learning	Macro: unclassified	Finance: corporate
Corporate	Micro: unclassified	Macro: transition	Micro: contract theory
Development	Macro: transition	Macro: growth	International: unclassified
Urban	Labor	Law and economics	Public finance
History	Productivity	Development	Other
Experimental	Micro: auctions	Micro: social choice	Micro: game theory
Productivity	Macro: growth	Industrial organization	History
Political economy	Micro: social choice	Law and economics	Macro: transition
Environmental	Public finance	Development	Micro: welfare economics
Law and economics	Political economy	Urban	Macro: transition
Other	History	Political economy	Urban

Table A1: Closest fields in the field-distance measure

7 Result map

- The slowdown is large and widespread.
- Longer first responses explain only part of it.
- Revision intensity is central.
- Democratization does not explain the pattern.
- Complexity has limited support: longer papers matter, specialization does not.
- Growth and competition explain part of the slowdown.
- Social norms remain a plausible residual explanation.

8 Short summary

Ellison documents a large slowdown in economics journal publishing and evaluates many possible causes. The core finding is that more extensive revisions are central, while many observable changes in the profession explain only part of the phenomenon. The paper therefore points toward evolving social norms about publication standards.

9 Conclusion

9.1 Core conclusion

The economics publication process slowed dramatically, with much of the increase driven by more extensive revision requirements.

9.2 Economic intuition

The journal review process is an institution that allocates economists' time. More revisions may improve papers, but they also reduce time for new research and slow diffusion.

9.3 Incremental contribution

The paper turns a professional complaint into a data-driven institutional analysis. It documents the slowdown, decomposes it, tests many explanations, and connects the residual to social norms.

9.4 Policy implications

Journals should report first-response and total acceptance times, editors should assess the marginal value of additional revision rounds, and the profession should recognize the career and productivity costs of long publication cycles.

9.5 Takeaway

Publishing norms can change gradually and impose large aggregate costs. The slowdown is therefore a central topic for the economics of science and academic institutions.